cold-shouldered by the Ghani government. The deep schisms within Afghanistan's body politic makes it difficult to simultaneously maintain cordial ties with different political actors in that country. If during Najibullah's tenure India found it tricky to independently develop links with the Khalq or even the Mujahideen (which was done covertly), the same was the case (though to a lesser extent) during Karzai's presidency when India's relations with non-Pashtun leaders came under political strain (though they never broke down).

Underlining the role of the international political environment, the United Nations' (UN) legitimisation of the Mujahideen government in 1992 allowed the conciliators to chart an accommodative approach. This happened despite the fact that it was Pakistan and Saudi Arabia that brokered truce between various Mujahideen factions in Peshawar. However, the UN's failure to sustain peace subsequently and Pakistan's support to the Taliban after 1994 paved the way for the rise of the partisans (who initially collaborated with Iran and Russia to oppose the Taliban militarily, but afterwards, got active support from the US as well). Institutionalisation of the reconciliation process with the Afghan Taliban at the 2010 London conference on Afghanistan jolted the partisans, who remained vehemently opposed to the idea. Almost automatically, the influence of the conciliators rose in the power corridors of New Delhi. However, Ghani's outreach to Pakistan in 2015, contributed to strengthening the partisan narrative for a brief period under the government of PM Narendra Modi. Given the tumultuous course of India's engagement with Afghanistan, it can be safely argued that there is no single policy that New Delhi practices towards Kabul. Instead, India's foreign policy approach towards Afghanistan has a kaleidoscopic quality wherein the interplay of multiple ideas advocated by different actors—partisans and conciliators—over time and in evolving scenarios, produces changing policy patterns.

The fact that the rise and fall of partisans and conciliators, more often than not, mirrors the changing situation on the ground in Afghanistan and the international political environment, corroborates the popular criticism that India's Afghanistan policy is reactive in nature. But, at the same time, it disproves the charge that India lacks clarity of thought, the power of will, and strategic decisiveness in Afghanistan. For, being reactive does not necessarily mean lacking political judgment and a clear sense of national interests, or devising ways to